



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MIN 523 (M) Life-Saving Appliances - Open Reversible Liferafts (ORLs) - UK Over Capacity and Servicing Exemption

Updated 27 April 2021

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Notice to all Owners and Operators of United Kingdom Domestic Passenger Ships of Class III to VI(A), ORL Manufacturers and ORL Service Station.

This Note replaces MGN 499 (M+F) for the UK Policy on ORL over capacity liferafts and the UK ORL servicing exemption.

This MIN expires 25 April 2026.

Summary

This Note provides information on the MCA policy with regards to Open Reversible Liferafts (ORLs) and the UK certification of such liferafts for over capacity use on Class III to VI(A) vessels, as well as the UK servicing exemption for ORLs. The ORL Exemption is contained within the annex to this Note.

1. Introduction

1.1 This Note replaces any previous information for the UK over-capacity allowance and exemption to the annual servicing of Open Reversible

Liferafts (ORLs) fitted to Class III to VI(A) domestic passenger vessels in accordance with the Merchant Shipping (Life Saving Appliances for Passenger Ships of Classes III to VI(A)) Regulation 1999, supplemented by MSN 1676.

1.2 Vessels certified under the Directive 2009/45/EC of the European Parliament and of the Council on safety rules and standards for passenger ships (as amended), the Safety Code for Passenger Ships operating on Categorised Waters (MSN 1823), and the Small Seagoing Passenger Ships Code (MGN 535) should comply with the relevant provisions for liferafts in those standards.

2. UK Over Capacity Open Reversible Liferafts for Class III to VI(A) Vessels

2.1 Part 4 of Schedule 4 to MSN 1676 sets out the permissible technical performance standards for non-SOLAS liferafts, which allows for a liferaft capacity which is about 22% above that which would otherwise be required for High Speed Craft Code (SOLAS Certificated) ORLs compliant with the Council Directive 96/98/EC of 20 December 1996 on Marine Equipment as amended (MED).

2.2 ORLs compliant with, and certificated against, the standard in Part 4 of Schedule 4 to MSN 1676 are to be described as “UK Certificated ORL” and the containers of UK Certificated ORLs are required by the aforementioned MSN and Regulations to be marked as NON- SOLAS REVERSIBLE.

2.3 It is for the reasons explained in the paragraphs above that the contents of this Note has not been included in MGN 548 but it is imperative that, aside from the ORL Servicing Exemption described in this Notice, UK vessel operators, masters, agents and skippers use only UK Service Stations as described in MGN 548 for the servicing of UK Certificated ORLs.

2.4 With reference to UK Certificated ORLs, Paragraph 2.11 of Part 4 of Schedule 4 to MSN 1676 states that “no liferaft shall be approved with carrying capacity of less than 4 or greater than 65 persons, calculated or determined in accordance with the requirements of paragraph 2.10”. This policy is still extant. The UK does not have in place the statutory means to accept, nor the ability to allow the issue of certificates of type approval to ORLs of greater than 65 person capacity under the Merchant Shipping

(Life-Saving Appliances for Passenger Ships of Classes III to VI(A)) Regulations 1999.

2.5 The MCA is aware that historically some UK Certificates of Type Approval have been issued for certain brands of UK Certificated ORL of over 65 capacity for reasons of local operational considerations. Since 2009 the MCA has applied a policy that no UK Certificated ORLs of greater than 65 person capacity shall be fitted to new or existing vessels after 19 July 2009. This policy remains in place but it should be noted that UK certificated ORLs of greater than 65 persons capacity already installed on board UK Class III to VI(A) ships shall be accepted until the liferaft reaches the end of its serviceable life. It will be necessary for the operators to ensure that the Certificate of Approval is retained on board each vessel.

2.6 It has been agreed that when the owners/operators of UK Class III to VI(A) passenger vessels need to replace any existing oversized ORLs of greater than 65 person capacity (because they have reached the end of their serviceable life), they may replace the liferaft with either an MED Approved ORL of comparative size or a greater quantity of UK Certificated (Non-SOLAS) ORLs limited to 65 person capacity.

2.7 UK Certificated ORLs should be type approved by UK Nominated Bodies.

3. Servicing Exemption for UK Open Reversible Liferafts for Class III to VI(A) Vessels

3.1 The MCA has granted an Exemption to the annual servicing of UK Certificated (Non-SOLAS) ORLs fitted to Class III to VI(A) domestic passenger vessels. This is shown in ANNEX 1 to this Note and allows the vessel owner/operator to omit the 2nd year, 4th year, 6th year and 8th year annual servicing intervals from the service schedule for UK Certificated ORLs only.

3.2 The Schedule to the annexed General Exemption specifically indicates the particular servicing intervals and test methods applicable to UK Certificated ORLs fitted on Class III to VI(A) Passenger Ships. The ORL servicing exemption does not apply to MED Certificated ORLs intended to meet the requirements of the High Speed Craft Code or the Merchant Shipping (High Speed Craft) Regulation 2004), nor does it apply to other SOLAS Certificated liferafts fitted to Class III to VI(A) Passenger Ships.

More Information

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Annex 1

General Exemption

THE MERCHANT SHIPPING (LIFE-SAVING APPLIANCES FOR PASSENGER SHIPS OF CLASSES III TO VI (A)) REGULATIONS 1999

The Secretary of State in exercise of his power under regulation 23 of the Merchant Shipping (Life-Saving Appliances for Passenger Ships of Classes III to VI(A)) Regulations 1999 (SI 1999/2723); hereby exempts ships to which the Regulations apply from the requirement of Regulation 11(7) that requires open reversible liferafts, complying with the requirements of Part 4 of Schedule 4 of MSN 1676 (M) to be serviced at intervals not exceeding 12 months, subject to the following conditions:

1. such open reversible liferafts shall be serviced;
 - (a) at intervals not exceeding two years; and

(b) within the periods stated in the attached Schedule, such periods being measured from the date of manufacture; and

1. the servicing includes the test methods stated in the attached Schedule according to the age of the open reversible liferaft.

This exemption shall not apply to open reversible liferafts carried on High Speed Craft (as defined in the Merchant Shipping (High Speed Craft) Regulations 2004), nor does it apply to other SOLAS Certificated liferafts fitted to Class III to VI(A) Passenger Ships.

This exemption cancels the general exemption within Annex 1 of MGN 499.

This exemption, which may be cancelled or modified at any time, shall otherwise remain in force until 25th April 2026.

Dated this [sixth day of May 2016] Signature on the original document on file

Ms Katy Ware For the Secretary of State

Schedule to Annex 1

SERVICING INTERVALS AND TEST METHODS FOR OPEN REVERSIBLE LIFERAFTS CARRIED ON PASSENGER SHIPS OF CLASSES III TO VI(A)

Servicing intervals	Test method
End of first year	WP test
End of third year	WP test
End of fifth year	GI test
End of seventh year	WP test
End of ninth year	WP test
End of tenth year	GI test + FS
Eleventh to fourteenth year	NAP test + FS

Servicing intervals	Test method
Fifteenth year	GI test + NAP + FS
Sixteenth to nineteenth year	NAP test + FS
Twentieth year	GI test + NAP + FS
Twenty-first to twenty-fourth year	NAP test + FS
Twenty-fifth year	GI test + NAP + FS
Etc.	GI test + NAP + FS

NAP - Necessary additional pressure test

WP - Working pressure (compressed air)

GI - Gas Inflation

FS - Floor seam



OGI

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